

Shaozhe Cheng

Curriculum Vitae

May, 2026

Department of Psychology & Neuroscience Homepage: <https://chengshaozhe.github.io>
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Positions

Postdoc Associate, Duke University & UCLA 2024-
Collaborators: [Tamar Kushnir](#), [Michael Tomasello](#), & [Tao Gao](#)

Education

Ph.D., Cognitive Psychology, Zhejiang University 2023
Advisors: Jifan Zhou (ZJU), Mowei Shen (ZJU), Tao Gao (UCLA)
Dissertation: *On the nature and origins of the unique human mind: Intentional commitment under conflicting desires* (**Outstanding Doctoral Dissertation Award**)

B.S., Psychology, Shanghai Normal University 2016

Research Interests

Computational cognitive science; social cognition; decision-making; agency; human–AI coordination; cooperative AI

Awards and Honors

- Travel Award, Charles Lafitte Foundation 2026
- Early-Career Scholar, [Intentions & AI Workshop](#) 2025
- Outstanding Doctoral Dissertation Award of Zhejiang Province 2024
- Outstanding Doctoral Dissertation Award of Zhejiang University 2023
- Grant for Excellence in Doctoral Research 2022
- Cognitive Science Society Conference Award 2021
- National Scholarship for Postgraduates 2017

Publications

Pre-prints/working papers

Cheng, S., Gao T., Tomasello, M., & Kushnir, T. The Agency Gap: Testing Human–Human and Human–AI Collaboration Using a Minimal Coordination Game. (6-page paper accepted at *CogSci* 2026, presented as a **spotlight** research talk (top 10%) at [Conference on Society-Centered AI](#).)

Tomasello, M., & **Cheng, S.** (invited submission). Can We Get to Human-Like Intelligence Via Language Alone?

Cheng, S., Zhu, J., Zhou J., Shen, M., & Gao T. Should we commit or should we switch? Goal alignment in sequential social coordination. (6-page paper accepted as a **talk** (9.3%) at *CogSci* 2026)

Journal Articles

Cheng, S., Zhu, J., Zhou J., Shen, M., & Gao T. (2026). Spontaneous coordination with self-commitment: How the presence of others alters the strength, goal and timing of commitment. *Cognition*. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.cognition.2025.106287>

Cheng, S., Zhao, M., Tang, N., Zhao, Y., Zhou J., Shen, M., & Gao T. (2023). Intention beyond desire: Spontaneous intentional commitment regulates conflicting desires. *Cognition*, 238, 105513. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.cognition.2023.105513>

Zhai, S[#], **Cheng, S[#]**, Moskowitz, N., Shen, M., & Gao, T. (2024). The development of commitment: Attention for intention. *Child Development*, 95(1), 7-15. <https://doi.org/10.1111/cdev.13955>

Shared first authors

Cheng, S., Shi, B., Zhao, Y., Tang, N., Xu., H., Gao, T., Zhou J., & Shen, M. (2017) Rethinking attention: A reinforcement learning model of attention. *Chinese Journal of Applied Psychology*.

Peer-Reviewed Conference Proceedings

Cheng, S., Zhu, J., Zhou J., Shen, M., & Gao T. (2024). Intentional commitment as a spontaneous presentation of self. In *Proceedings of the 46th Annual Conference of the Cognitive Science Society*.

Cheng, S., Zhao, M., Zhu, J., Zhou J., Shen, M., & Gao T. (2022). Intentional commitment through an internalized theory of mind: Acting in the eyes of an imagined observer. In *Proceedings of the 44th Annual Conference of the Cognitive Science Society*.

Cheng, S., Zhao, M., Zhu, J., Zhou J., Shen, M., & Gao T. (2022). Intentional commitment as goal perseverance in human planning [Workshop on Social Intelligence in Humans and Robots]. *The annual meeting of the Robotics: Science and Systems 2022 (RSS 2022)*. (presented as a **spotlight** paper at <https://social-intelligence-human-ai.github.io/>)

Zhai, S., **Cheng, S.**, Moskowitz, N., Shen, M., & Gao, T. (2022). The development of commitment: Attention for intention. In *Proceedings of the 44th Annual Conference of the Cognitive Science Society*.

Cheng, S., Tang, N., An, W., Zhao, Y., Zhou J., Shen, M., & Gao T. (2021). Intention beyond desire: Humans Spontaneously Commit to Future Actions. In *Proceedings of the 43rd Annual Conference of the Cognitive Science Society*.

Conference Presentations

[^]Students I supervised

Kushnir, T., & **Cheng, S.** (2026, Apr). Children's strategic joint decision-making with minimally social artificial agents. Pre-Conference Workshops on *Strategic decision-making in childhood*, Cognitive Development Society (CDS), Montreal, Quebec, Canada.

Cheng, S., Gao T., Tomasello, M., & Kushnir, T. (2026, Feb). The Agency Gap: Testing Human-Human and Human-AI Collaboration Using a Minimal Coordination Game. Presented as a spotlight research talk (top 10%) at *Conference on Society-Centered AI*, Duke University, Durham, NC, USA.

Cheng, S., Main, K[^], Kushnir, T., & Gao, T. (2025, May). Spontaneous social

coordination through visually grounded theory-of-mind in children's and adults' decision-making. Poster accepted at *the Annual Meeting of the Vision Sciences Society*, St. Pete Beach, Florida, USA.

- Cheng, S., Main, K.[^], Gao, T., & Kushnir, T.** (2025, May). Children's Spontaneous Commitment and Intention Coordination in Individual and Social Decision-Making Contexts. Talk at the Symposium: Unravelling early and middle childhood decision-making: From individual characteristics to social influences, *Society for Research in Child Development Biennial Meeting (SRCD 2025)*, Minneapolis, MN, USA.
- Cheng, S., Zhu, J.[^], Zhou J., Shen, M., & Gao T.** (2024). From attention capture to social coordination: "Abrupt onset" rallies joint planning. Poster presented at the 2024 VSS Annual Meeting. Vision Sciences Society.
- Zhu, J.[^], **Cheng, S.**, Gao T., Shen, M., & Zhou J. (2023). Viewing others as committed agents. Poster presented at *the 2023 SPSP Annual Convention. Society for Personality and Social Psychology*.
- Zhu, J.[^], **Cheng, S.**, Gao T., Shen, M., & Zhou J. (2023). Intention as hierarchical constraints in human planning. Poster presented at *the 2023 VSS Annual Meeting. Vision Sciences Society*.
- Zhu, J.[^], **Cheng, S.**, Gao T., Shui, R., Shen, M., & Zhou J. (2023). People expect others to plan with consistency to intention. Poster presented at *the 2023 APS Annual Convention. Association for Psychological Science*.
- Zhai, S., **Cheng, S.**, Moskowitz, N., Shen, M., & Gao, T. (2022). The development of commitment: Attention for intention. Oral presentation at *the Annual Meeting of the Cognitive Science Society*.
- Cheng, S.**, Tang, N., An, W., Zhao, Y., Zhou J., Shen, M., & Gao T. (2021). Intention beyond desire: Commitment in human action. Poster presented at *the 47th annual meeting of the Society for Philosophy and Psychology*, 6/28/21 – 7/2/21, *Virtual-SPP*.
- Cheng, S.**, Tang, N., An, W., Zhao, Y., Zhou J., Shen, M., & Gao T. (2020). Intention beyond desire: Commitment in human action. Poster presented at *the annual meeting of the Vision Sciences Society*, 6/19/20 – 6/24/20, *Virtual-VSS*.
- Cheng, S.**, Xu, H., Tang, N., Zhou J., Chen, H., Liang, J., Gao T., & Shen, M. (2018). Hierarchical Constrains on the Distribution of Attention in Dynamic Displays. Poster presented at *the 30th APS Annual Convention*.

Grant & Fellowship

Under review

National Science Foundation
(United States)

**Exploring Collaborative Decision-Making in Children
in Order to Create Better Artificial Social Agents**

*Collaborators: Tamar Kushnir (Duke), Tao Gao (UCLA),
Michael Tomasello (Duke)*

Invited Talks

Cheng, S. Test commitment in humans (adults and kids) and AIs (RL agents and LLMs) in sequential decision-making. Talk given at the [Intentions & AI Workshop](#), CA, 6/2/2025.

Cheng, S. On the nature and origins of the unique human mind: Intentional commitment under conflicting desires. Talk given at the Tomasello Lab, Duke University, NC, 4/18/2025.

Cheng, S. Spontaneous coordination through intentional commitment: How adults and children resolve conflicting desires in sequential decision-making. Talk given at the Communication Colloquium, UCLA, CA, 4/10/2025.

Teaching

Teaching Assistant **Zhejiang University: Psychology and Artificial Intelligence**
(undergraduate course), 2018 & 2019

Guest Lecturer **Zhejiang University: Evolutionary Psychology** (undergraduate seminar), 2017 & 2018
Zhejiang University: Advanced Psychological Research Methods
(graduate course), 2019 & 2020

Mentorship

<i>PhD Students</i>	Jingyin Zhu (ZJU '24)
<i>Master Students</i>	Shaoyan Hao (ZJU '25)
<i>Undergraduate Senior Theses</i>	Kaelin Main (Duke '25)
	Camila Acquarone (Duke '27)

Award & Funding to Trainees

Duke Summer Vertical Integration Program (VIP)	Riley MacDermott (Duke '27)	2026
Duke Summer Vertical Integration Program (VIP)	Kaelin Main (Duke '25)	2024

Ad Hoc Reviewer

Science Robotics
Journal of Experimental Psychology: General
Cognition
The Annual Meeting of the Cognitive Science Society
Society for Philosophy and Psychology